



Scuola Superiore Meridionale

CALL FOR PAPER - International Conference

Violence and Empire. From the Early 1800s to the End of the Great War

Scuola Superiore Meridionale, Naples, Italy, 6 and 7 March 2026



Remnants of an Army (Elizabeth Thompson, 1879)

From the early 1800s, the formation, consolidation, and maintenance of empires were increasingly bound to new logics of state power, technological advancements, and legal rationalisation and justification. Despite narratives of civilising missions and administrative modernisation, violence remained a central practice of imperial rule, both as an instrument of conquest and a mechanism for governing already established colonial regimes. This conference invites historians and scholars of related disciplines to consider the various ways in which violence operated within imperial systems, how it was implemented, codified and justified legally and culturally, along with its contemporary perception in the imperial metropolis and its remembrance and subsequent legacies that continuously remain influential until the present day.

This conference will explore the multifaceted relationship between violence and empire, focusing on the long nineteenth century, ending with the Great War. It aims to bring together scholars working on the history of empires, colonialism, imperial rule, and its perception, legal regimes, military cultures, and political modernity, to foster a fruitful dialogue on the roles played by violence in shaping the

manifestations of imperialism and its lasting legacies. The event will be held in person at the Scuola Superiore Meridionale (SSM) in Naples, and the working language will be English.

The organising committee is particularly interested in contributions that consider the dynamic interaction between coercive practices, legal, institutional, and ideological developments in imperial contexts. In this respect, the conference aims at addressing the following questions: what forms did violence take in different imperial settings, and how did it interact with broader political and cultural imaginaries? How was violence operationalised by both state and non-state actors such as colonial administrators, paramilitary organisations, missionaries, settlers, and local intermediaries? How was it narrated, justified or silenced in imperial metropolises, and how did legal and bureaucratic frameworks attempt to regulate and rationalise it?

We welcome research that engages with violence not merely as a discrete or episodic phenomenon, but as a constitutive force in empire-building, colonial governance, and postcolonial statehood. We are particularly interested in how violence was institutionalised through policing, penal regimes, forced labour, and the military occupation of space. Equally, we seek to investigate the rhetorical and symbolic dimensions of imperial violence, from its justification in legal doctrine and international law to its representation in media, literature, and contemporary popular culture. In this sense, the conference moves beyond purely material analyses of violence to explore its affective, cultural, and ideological functions.

This call is open to scholars whose work explores a wide range of imperial contexts – British, French, German, Ottoman, Russian, Dutch, Belgian, Portuguese, Italian, Japanese, Chinese, Spanish, or beyond – focusing on comparative, connected, or transimperial dimensions of imperial violence. We particularly encourage proposals that examine how imperial violence operated across boundaries: between metropole and colony; between legal and extralegal domains; between past and present. Submissions may focus on specific case studies or adopt broader analytical approaches. They may be comparative, theoretical or empirical. Themes of interest include, but are not limited to:

- The administration of punishment, coercion, and discipline in imperial spaces.
- Policing, surveillance, and the bureaucratisation of force and coercion.
- Legal discourses and the production of norms around "legitimate" violence.
- The role of international law in justifying imperial conquest and control.
- Military campaigns, pacification strategies, and settler colonial violence.
- The perceptions of colonial violence in the imperial metropolis.
- Forced mobility, migration, and imperial strategies of movement control
- Indigenous resistance, insurgencies, and anti-colonial mobilisation.
- Race, gender, and class as vectors for the experience and application of violence.
- The global circulation of coercive techniques and military expertise.

By situating violence within the broader historical processes of imperial modernity, the conference aims to offer a platform for an international and interdisciplinary discourse with pressing questions of political legitimacy, state formation, and global inequality. It invites scholars to reflect not only on the past but on the enduring impact of imperial violence in shaping modern regimes of governance, security, and rights.

We invite proposals from scholars at all career stages, and we particularly encourage early-career researchers. Contributions from scholars working in related fields, such as legal studies, political theory, anthropology, postcolonial studies, and international relations, are welcome.

The organising committee is open to publishing a collective volume including selected contributions from conference participants. Further details will be shared during the conference.

The conference will be organised over two days (March 6 and 7) of presentations and discussions, interspersed with coffee breaks and a light lunch on the second day. We will also be hosting a conference dinner, which all participants are more than welcome to join. The event will be inaugurated and concluded by keynote addresses delivered by Professor Tanja Bührer and Dr Georgina Sinclair.

Please submit an abstract of no more than 300 words, written in English, along with a short academic bio (max 150 words), and five keywords, to imperialviolence2025@gmail.com by November 16. Selected participants will be notified by January 9.

Organizing and Scientific Committee: Julius Lucas Becker, Luca Bertolani Azeredo, Alessandro Bonvini, Adrian Jesús Cabrera Bibilonia, Alina Castellanos Rubio, Olindo De Napoli, Massimiliano Giuseppe Del Gaudio, Eleonora Ferrazzi, Thaïs Gendry, Alessia Orlandi.

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